

Why We Crave "Comfort Food"

RAT NAR ORE, Res EAE, ARIMA 是热量，而是记忆。回味那份温馨，无需食物，心也能定。

When under severe emotional distress, adults often turn to what psychologist Joyce Brothers coined in 1966 as "comfort food" — food heavily associated with the security of childhood. For some, it might be a dish of buckwheat groats and bow-tie noodles, while for others, comfort comes in a bowl of pasta with a great-grandmother's tomato sauce. When there is no time for old-world cooking, ice cream frequently serves the purpose. This fundamental human craving relies deeply on meals imbued with memories of feeling safe and cared for.

Back in Brothers' day, most comfort foods would have been homemade or minimally processed. In the decades since, however, food manufacturers have utilized increasingly sophisticated technologies to create affordable, highly processed versions of favorite comfort meals. Calorie-laden and heavy on salt, fat, and sugar, these ultraprocessed iterations make today's comfort foods more bingeable and significantly less healthy than those of previous generations. Thanks to the modern world's demand for convenience, the odds are remarkably high that a preferred comfort food falls into this heavily refined category.

These products approximate their homemade analogs with extracted ingredients, stabilizers, and flavor enhancers designed to maximize shelf life and palatability. Crucially, ultraprocessed foods are dangerously easy to overeat. The manufacturing process strips away the ingredients' innate structure, requiring less chewing and allowing the product to go down quicker. Research indicates that individuals consume them at a much faster rate than unprocessed alternatives, taking in up to twice as many calories per minute. Beyond mere

overindulgence, scientists possess evidence that these packaged foods, particularly sweet ones, can hijack the brain's reward system to create a genuinely addictive effect.

To sidestep the link between ultraprocessing and comfort, nutrition scientists are working to understand the underlying mechanisms that lift our moods. They have discovered that the soothing sensation stems primarily from a psychological connection rather than the nutritional profile itself. Sociologists have found that individuals harbor deep emotional attachments to particular dishes they ate as children, turning to those foods during bouts of loneliness. It is, in essence, classical conditioning. People learn to associate specific foods with positive emotions during celebrations or gatherings, and that connection gets strengthened across a lifetime. Consequently, comfort food remains highly personal and culturally varied, whether one seeks carbohydrate-heavy indulgence or a restorative broth with fresh herbs.

Nostalgia, that wistful yearning for a time when you felt happy and connected to others, acts as a key element of this psychological power. Social psychologists exploring the links between food nostalgia, social connectedness, and comfort have found that the more nostalgia a food inspires, the more likely it is to make a person feel comforted. In fascinating experiments, participants who merely visualized the experience of eating certain foods and wrote about it experienced emotional benefits without actually consuming a single bite. This suggests that the psychological component, specifically the pairing of a food's personal meaning and social context, overrides the active mechanics of tasting or chewing.

Building upon this psychological foundation, scientists have explored whether we can recondition our brains to connect comfort with healthier choices, thereby finding solace without indulgence. In one

notable experiment, individuals listened to recorded relaxation sessions while eating fruit over the course of a week. The Pavlovian connection succeeded. Participants subsequently reported a greater decrease in negative emotions when eating the fruit alone, indicating their brains had learned to associate relaxation with nutritious produce.

Taking this research a step further, studies measuring psychological recovery after acute stress have revealed a surprising truth.

Everyone's mood rebounds eventually, whether they consume their favorite ultraprocessed food, fresh produce, or nothing at all.

Negative feelings simply ebb with the passage of time. There is no extra mood boost beyond normal psychological recovery, meaning we may be giving comfort foods credit for a natural emotional lift we would experience anyway. Recognizing that there is nothing uniquely comforting about the act of eating calorie-dense foods liberates stressed individuals to seek relief elsewhere. Moving forward, those yearning for a soothing retreat might find that sketching their favorite dessert or visualizing a cherished culinary memory offers all the solace they need.